

## IN CONTEXT

### The Romantic movement

Berlioz's life coincided with the rise of the Romantic movement, which affected literature, painting, and music. Reacting to the rationalism of the Enlightenment, there arose a taste for conveying themes that were bizarre, exotic, violent, or macabre. Berlioz was drawn to such subjects. His winning entry for the Prix de Rome was a cantata, *The Death of Sardanapalus*—a scene of butchery made notorious in a painting by Eugène Delacroix. Similarly, Berlioz's *Symphonie fantastique* climaxes in a witches' sabbath, a favorite theme of Spanish painter Francisco Goya.



THE DEATH OF SARDANAPALUS, EUGENE  
DELACROIX, 1827

Born in a village near Grenoble, Hector Berlioz was the eldest of six children. His father, Louis, a highly respected country doctor, was one of the first Westerners to use acupuncture in his treatments. He took a